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Utopian anti-utopianism: rethinking Cold War liberalism through British anarchism

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ABSTRACT

Isaiah Berlin's "Two Concepts of Liberty" lecture was the iconic statement of Cold War liberalism, an expression of all its insights and limitations. It divided critics then and now: was it a stimulating restatement of classical liberalism with revitalising potential for post-war democracy or a conservative retreat from politics that paralysed liberalism as both a social and political force? This article approaches the debate from a side angle. It looks at how the *Freedom* anarchist group addressed the problems raised by the lecture. Of all ideologies, anarchism most elevated liberty as the highest good. At the same time, it considered itself a social movement for the advance of liberty. As such, the tension highlighted by "Two Concepts", between the intrinsic value of liberty and the pursuit of liberty, had long preoccupied generations of anarchist thinkers but never more so than after the War, where inherited assumptions about revolution and social change became implausible. Although Berlin identified anarchism with the fullest realisation of positive liberty, the movement was more philosophically diverse than he recognised. The *Freedom* group's responses to his dilemma of liberty demonstrates this. At the same time, their efforts to think beyond the impasse and experiment with new forms of political practice – as exemplified by *Anarchy*, *Freedom*'s sister publication – outstripped those of the liberals casting fresh light on the limits and possibilities of freedom in a Cold War world.

KEYWORDS

Negative Liberty; Permanent protest; Constructive anarchy

Isaiah Berlin's "Two Concepts of Liberty" lecture (31 October 1958) was the iconic statement of Cold War liberalism. In it, he reformulated a longstanding distinction between negative and positive liberty. The former, "free from", referred to the classical liberal notion of liberty as non-interference, while the latter, "free to", meant something closer to self-mastery. For Berlin, negative liberty was undoubtedly the stronger account of freedom. While he accepted positive liberty, self-mastery, as a worthwhile value to pursue, and heavily implicated in the exercise of freedom, it was not the same thing. Moreover, it had often been vulnerable to abuse.¹

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“Two Concepts” condensed both the strengths and limits of Cold War liberalism. For Gerald MacCullum and Charles Taylor, Berlin’s division was artificial,² dismissive of effective freedom (capacity to act), inattentive to psychological constraints and ambivalent about social injustice.³ Nancy Hirschman too suggested that the “Two Concepts” assumptions about the individual ignored marginalised groups like women,⁴ while Quentin Skinner argued that non-interference was too fragile a basis for freedom compared to the republican concept of non-domination outlined by Philip Pettit.⁵ In reply, George Crowder protested its nuance, especially when viewed in relation to Berlin’s “tempered” value pluralism which, reviling moral monism, accepted the validity (if not the equality) of different kinds of freedom.⁶

Situating “Two Concepts” in its Cold War context, Jan-Werner Müller agreed Berlin’s pluralism and anti-determinism provided Cold War liberalism with an intellectual core, allowing him to argue with Marxism philosophically. At the same time, Müller conceded that this core did not constitute a cohesive programme.⁷ Seizing on this, Samuel Moyn argued that the scepticism generated by value pluralism and anti-determinism made producing a coherent political programme for its advance or defence impossible. This left liberalism defenceless in the face of aggressive illiberal alternatives.⁸ Joshua Cherniss, however, saw Berlin and others transforming liberalism from a set of institutions and procedures into an “ethos” based on pro-social personal virtues like tolerance, humility and prudence (all of which allow people to live with difference without resorting to conflict) but offered no sense of how this ethos was to be propagated and mobilised, how it would address structural inequalities or what implications it would have for customary understandings of change and action.⁹

Was “Two Concepts” (as the representative text of British Cold War liberalism) a creative restatement of the liberal case for liberty or a descent into apathy and inertia? This article tackles the question from a side angle, by looking at how the British *Freedom* anarchists responded to the lecture’s dilemmas. Considering the anarchists’ perspective on the “Two Concepts” problem magnifies the philosophical and political issues at stake. No other ideology privileged individual liberty so highly. At the same time, anarchism was a revolutionary movement for an anarchist society. Reconciling these two aspects – the love of liberty with the pursuit of liberty – was a perennial source of tension among adherents who continually questioned whether liberty could ever be achieved through coercive means, or if a single, integrated society devoted to freedom was compatible with freedom in practice.

Among the *Freedom* group, these debates intensified in the decade and a half following the Second World War. Founded by Peter Kropotkin in 1886, *Freedom* was Britain’s longest-running anarchist periodical and the main platform for scrutinising the past, present and future of the movement. After declining following Kropotkin’s death in 1921, it was rescued by Italian anarchists Vernon Richards and Marie Louise Berneri in 1936, who used it to promote the Spanish anarchists and later to oppose the War. In 1945, it reverted to *Freedom*. By 1947, the editorial board included, among others, writer George Woodcock and architect-journalist Colin Ward, who went on to be the founder editor of *Freedom*’s sister paper, *Anarchy: A Journal of Anarchist Ideas* (1961–1970). Prominent intellectuals Herbert Read and Alex Comfort, as well as leading radical orator Rita Milton, were also regular contributors.

Berlin himself would have doubted the anarchists had anything to contribute to a debate on liberty and liberalism. He believed them the guiltiest of all for confusing a plan for freedom with the experience of it. With characteristic irony, he “credited” anarchism as the only movement “brave” enough to fully embrace the Enlightenment ideal that liberty meant alignment with reason and/or laws of nature.¹⁰ In fact, this was wrong: anarchism always encompassed a broad range of positions and never more so than during the post-war period. There were many who saw Berlin’s pluralist anti-determinism as entirely compatible with their notion of anarchy. Indeed, some considered anarchy, properly understood, to be the logical extension of Berlin’s argument.

That said, prevailing accounts of post-war British anarchy suggest a different story. Typically, they emphasise the rise of “new anarchism”, which, as Benjamin Pauli and Carissa Honeywell describe it, reframed anarchy from popular insurrection and total revolution to being a holistic way of life aligned to a scientific understanding of human social development, advancing a gradual, piecemeal, but nevertheless systematic revolution.¹¹ Laurance Davis too notes how the turn to so-called “lifestyle anarchism” marked the movement’s increased maturity in recognising the interplay of personal and social transformation.¹²

So far, this seems to confirm Berlin’s charge; nevertheless, there has been resistance to this view. One school of thought, including contemporaries Albert Meltzer, George Woodcock and Murray Bookchin, rejected “new anarchism” as a straightforward retreat from serious revolutionary politics and a decline into depoliticised reformism.¹³ Others stopped short of that, but agreed it was only an update of long-standing “Tolstoyan” or Christian anarchist variants, propelled to greater prominence by *Freedom*’s close association with the peace movement and subject to the same criticism that they had always been, namely a weak grasp of the nature of power and an unrealistic optimism about non-violent revolutionary strategy.¹⁴

Matthew Adams, by contrast, upholds the distinctiveness of new anarchism, but introduces a conciliatory note of pragmatism to it by observing how post-war conditions, not least the overwhelming encroachment of technology, including technocratic social management, necessitated a strong “counter” shift toward more humanist accounts and representations of anarchism.¹⁵ Adams also argues that even the most ardent advocates of new anarchism, like Read, valued its utopian aspects for their motivational properties as much as their promise of a new society.¹⁶

There was, however, another strain, distinct again from either the “old” or “new” anarchist camps or their modified forms. This strand, which David Stafford termed the “permanent protestors”, mirrored Cold War liberalism, and specifically Berlin’s account of negative liberty, by accepting non-interference as the more robust definition of freedom. Stafford, situating the movement firmly in the wider post/Cold War context, highlights this as a response to an increasingly fragmented and fragmenting political environment, questioning its own foundational concepts (such as “equality” among the left, “liberty” among the liberals). Nevertheless, despite recognising the critical value of non-interference, Stafford found its nihilistic qualities apolitical, another symptom of declining radicalism.¹⁷ In another sense, however, this missed the implicit radicalism of its implications, not least the fundamental challenge it posed to the idea of what a liberational politics entails.

Building on from Stafford, this article shows how certain components in British anarchism not only accepted the “Two Concepts” conundrum with its central tension between hypocrisy and paralysis but also used it as a springboard for a “utopian anti-utopianism”, a politics of criticism which made a virtue of imperfection and incompleteness. Drawing on articles and letters published in *Freedom* and *Anarchy* during 1947–1967, I first examine the background to post-war anarchism dwelling on the objections raised to Read and Comfort who, in different ways, most embodied, and advanced, the “new anarchism” agenda. I highlight Ward’s qualified response to “new anarchism” in contrast to his appreciation of Berlin’s “Freedom and Betrayal” lectures (broadcast on the B.B.C. *Third Programme*, 1952) and the “Open Society” position more generally.

Next, I turn to George Molnar’s case for “permanent protest” (1958), which argued that the movement should accept the modest but more coherent agenda of sustained criticism. Milton, the British anarchists’ leading orator, welcomed “permanent protest” as the theory most consistent with anarchist principles but others were dissatisfied with its lack of ambition. The final section spotlights George Leval’s notion of “constructive propaganda” as a technique for encouraging independent states of mind. It then returns to Ward, who blended Leval and Molnar to create *Anarchy*’s distinctive “radical realism” aesthetic. By openly displaying the limits and contingencies in anarchist ideas, he hoped to make them more palatable to mainstream discourse.

Anarchy and the Open Society

In his lecture, “Anarchism: Past and Future” (May 1947), Herbert Read argued that, in a nuclear age, governments held the means of absolute power, a fact with “decisive implications for revolutionary strategy”. Total revolution, in the sense traditionally imagined by the anarchists – a popular uprising and head-on collision with power – was now impossible. The movement must adapt or perish, but how?¹⁸

Read further argued that anarchism had been intellectually stagnant since Kropotkin’s *Mutual Aid* (1902), a natural history of co-operation among insect, animal and pre-industrial human societies. Had *Freedom*’s founder lived to complete his most ambitious work, *Ethics* (1922), an investigation into the biological basis of co-operation, modern anarchism might have advanced further. Unfortunately, he died before being able to prove “the consciousness of equity, which physiologically develops in man as in all social animals”.¹⁹ Read believed this idea offered the movement a way forward but considered psychology, not physiology, better suited to the project.²⁰

As Goodway observed, Read’s politics were entwined with his social and aesthetic philosophy, a sometimes-contradictory blend of rationalism and romanticism bearing a heavily Platonic stamp.²¹ Like Kropotkin, he believed anarchism was possible by understanding and aligning with nature instead of suppressing it beneath the artificial contrivances imposed by self-serving authority. At the same time, as Adams demonstrates, he was more concerned with inner nature than natural history, perceiving the mind in a constant state of growth and flux.²²

While the final truth and direction of this internal flux eluded comprehension, it was not entirely unknowable. One means of conveying it was through modern art, which, by rejecting custom and seeking novelty of form and expression, expressed its elemental shifts and changes. Once visible, these yielded to more sober inquiry. He developed

his theory on art's revelatory qualities in *Education Through Art* (1943), his influential treatise on pedagogy, which amplified Plato's "most passionate ideal" – that "art should be the basis of education" – by attaching it to psychology as the disciplined understanding of the mind, and analysing children's paintings for insights into their emerging characters.²³ In the May lecture, he resumed this theme, advising anarchists to attend to psychology as the all-important bridge between artistic expression and scientific analysis which should form the basis of social composition. He concluded by calling for the word "revolution", in its traditional usage, to be struck from the anarchist vocabulary and replaced by "education".²⁴

Alex Comfort developed Read's vision of anarchism as psychology translated into social order. Comfort, a psychiatrist, also believed anarchism was the outcome of a scientific understanding of human nature but was less optimistic than Read or Kropotkin about the inherent altruism of that nature. Not that it mattered, humans did not *need* to be naturally sociable for anarchism to work.

I believe that man has one unique property, his power of intelligent foresight which makes him able to deal intelligently with his environment and at the same time gives him a great capacity for anxiety and fear. I believe that there is no evidence that any of the things which human beings value (freedom, beauty) have any objective reality outside of man ... I believe in one ethical principle, the solidarity of man against death and against the human allies of death—those who side with Power.²⁵

Solidarity might stem from the desire for self-preservation, but this was still enough to guarantee order without the need for authority. In fact, Comfort found the idea that a state was necessary to ensure security contradictory. If all people were fundamentally self-interested, then giving a small group of them greater capacity to act than that given to others only ensured they were better able to protect their own interests against those of everyone else.

He expanded the theory in *Authority and Delinquency* (1950), which divided societies into "healthy" life-centred cultures that prioritised community, and death-orientated cultures, craving ever more power. In the latter category, further distinctions could be drawn between classical power centrism typified by racism, aggression, and misogyny, as in fascism, and new forms like Stalinism, which fetishised production and control. As with any disease, it could not be treated until it was properly understood, and that degree of discernment demanded the trained mind of a scientist. While Comfort accepted that activists had a part to play in stimulating revolution, their motivations were too emotive, their actions too small and haphazard to be effective. It was doctors who would create change:

[doctors] have long since become so used to dealing personally and without anger with individuals whose conduct seems to us foolish, wicked or psychopathic that no patient, however obnoxious, seems quite inaccessible ... medicine is used to enter into the thoughts and even the friendship of delinquents and psychopaths without sacrificing its own orientation.²⁶

As discussed above, Read and Comfort are considered to mark a break from classical anarchism's preoccupation with instigating a popular total revolution, but, at the time, many anarchists dismissed them out of hand as totally naïve.²⁷ Writer and railway worker Sidney Parker found Comfort's proposals so preposterous he could not resist teasing him,

No, comrade Comfort, I am afraid that if we wish to see tyranny eliminated and the order of anarchy prevail, it will be futile to dispense with the masses and to rely on the well-meaning but unrealistic and, up to the present, undefined efforts of the psychiatrist.²⁸

If Parker and others thought so-called “lifestyle anarchism” was naïve when it came to realities of power, this was not Colin Ward’s main worry. Ward has often been positioned as one of the principal architects of “new” anarchism,²⁹ but, as I argue elsewhere, his reception of its ideas was cautious, a critical sympathy counter-balanced with a pronounced scepticism. As such, while the *Freedom* editor shared Read and Comfort’s optimism for gradual, non-violent approaches to change, he worried about their over-reliance on science. Like his fellow critics, Ward was uncomfortable about the power that relying on the authority of science handed to intellectuals. As Stuart White observes, “social responsibility” formed the crux of Ward’s anarchism and anything that deferred or removed that from ordinary people struck him as deeply problematic.³⁰

His other problem was that both Read and Comfort took for granted that social science knowledge, provided it was done “objectively”, was “true”, but for Ward, writing in the *University Libertarian* (1955), there was room for doubt here: “I do not believe that the social sciences are objective like the physical sciences. I think they find what they are looking for”.³¹ This was not a bad thing, especially when they looked at things like autonomy and co-operation, but, nevertheless, it gave them a more limited authority than Read and Comfort envisaged.

Ward’s thinking on the role of knowledge and intellectuals in freedom was framed by Berlin’s “Freedom and Betrayal” series (broadcast on B.B.C. *Third Programme*, 1952), which included lectures on Rousseau, Fichte and Hegel. He admired Berlin immensely, collecting his articles and attending his lectures at the Pushkin Club. He even invited Berlin to speak to the London Anarchists but received a courteous note pleading overwork. It was not just Berlin’s specific arguments about freedom Ward found interesting – though he took their point to heart – but it was also the freedom of his style of thinking which struck him as an ideal. To him, the “Open Society” cherished by liberals like Berlin, but also figures like J.L. Talmon (*The Origins of Totalitarian Democracy*, 1952) and Karl Popper (*The Open Society*, 1945), meant promoting conditions which not merely allowed but nurtured such a freedom of thought. Anything dogmatic, even, or especially, about something like freedom, contradicted that end.

Ironically, the anarchists were often guilty of libertarian dogmatism. In a careful review article, Ward summarised the standard liberal critique of anarchism:

- (1) Anarchism is an idealist and perfectionist philosophy of personal freedom stemming ultimately from Rousseau ... ,
- (2) Anarchism in its rejection of compromises and lesser evils is like the varieties of religion ... ,
- (3) Anarchism often talks in a Messianic way of a revolution which is to inaugurate a golden age ... , and,
- (4) Anarchism makes the same false assumptions about human nature as those 18th century French philosophers.³²

Instead of leaping to the anarchists’ defence as one might expect, he simply agreed that “people are justified in raising them, as a glance at the world’s anarchist press will show”.

To be taken seriously, anarchists must cease attempting to define either human nature or the sort of society it would best flourish in. They should concentrate on the quality of freedom in the here and now.³³

Ward presented himself as a reasonable voice in an overheated debate, but not all were persuaded. P.M.M. Huggon accused him of sinking into the Cold War mire of the “Open Society Liberals” who, through their incessant scepticism, were no less oppressive of change than the radicals they accused.³⁴ Read too believed the “Open Society Liberals” hostility to utopian thinking impoverished their social vision,

[It induces] a despair, a nihilism. Dismissing any hope of a perfect society, however remote, he casts his eyes to the ground and contemplates with satisfaction the piecemeal methods of the mole. He makes his little burrow, throws up a little hill to show that there is ‘work in progress’. But the wide acres stretch all around him, and which should be growing corn for the hungry multitudes.³⁵

For Read, denying the utopian imagination meant stifling the pulse of change and suppressing society’s natural drive to reach beyond itself, but Ward, like Berlin, worried that the risks of utopia were greater than the reward. Too often, it throttled more change than it stimulated. As he put it, “taking the subject out of the utopian [puts it] into that of the practicable. Which in turn is moving it into the sphere of the possible”.³⁶

Permanent protest

These debates intensified among the anarchists after 1956, a watershed year for all British radicals. The combination of Khrushchev’s infamous speech exposing Stalinist atrocities and the Soviet Union’s consequent suppression of the Hungarian uprising propelled hundreds from the British Communist Party, a handful of whom began the first British New Left. This rupture was further compounded by the Suez disaster, Britain’s escalating nuclear programme and the increase in American military bases on British soil, which all electrified public attention, especially among students. The first Aldermaston march for nuclear disarmament took place in April 1958, attracting an unexpectedly high initial turnout of 6000 people in Trafalgar square.

As Lawrence Black observes, a through-running thread connecting this activity was widespread disillusionment with political parties and a revived interest in popular direct action.³⁷ There was an undeniably anarchic slant to the Aldermaston marchers and even to the New Left students when they insisted that socialism must be something people create for themselves. For all the disgruntlement and bold declarations, however, there was confusion and ambivalence about how all this political ferment should be expressed and channelled without repeating the same mistakes. While people might well have looked to *Freedom* for answers on how to create a free society, the anarchists themselves were divided on this subject, not least on the supposition that one even *should* attempt to create such a society.

In May 1958, *Freedom* reprinted “Anarchy and Utopia” by George Molnar, a Hungarian-Australian philosopher and leading figure in the Sydney University Freethinking and Libertarian Societies, as well as the Sydney Push, an attendant group of intellectuals, socialites and artists who scandalised with their drinking and outlandishly bohemian antics. Despite being no stranger to hedonism, Molnar’s article made a ferocious attack on utopianism of any kind. In doing so, it took certain intellectual cues from Australian Realism, the philosophy pioneered by John Anderson (1893–1962), his tutor.

Anderson's realism supposed a single, mind-independent reality. Here, things were things, facts about the world. Idealists were right to say things related to one another but erred when they overemphasised those relations and denied the reality of things in favour of an image held together in the mind. This was not, however, to say things had a permanent essence. To Anderson, the state of the world was one of continual conflict and change, but not in accordance with any internal laws or dialectical compulsion. Change was a certainty, the direction of it was not. In the end it came down to circumstance and chance. While the probability of change could be anticipated to some degree, change itself could only be truly understood after the fact, not predicted beforehand. Once this was grasped, it became clear that the only responsible intellectual work was to grasp things for what they were and dispel all myths of universal laws and higher realities.³⁸

Anderson's philosophy did not directly equate to a political position *per se*, but it informed his political views. In 1943, for example, he launched an attack against state planning, then in the zenith of its popularity among Australian intellectuals and politicians. Writing in the *Australian Journal of Psychology and Philosophy*, he complained that people who expected the state to supply them with "sufficient" would end up worse off than if they met their needs through their own organised efforts. Planning could never anticipate all that might happen, and people would be left vulnerable if they became too dependent. He further worried that a rich high culture depended on a plurality of movements taking their chance in a constant social struggle.³⁹ Anything that prevented individuals exercising their private reason, up to and including laws and notions of rights, detracted from both personal and public freedoms.

Anderson was not an anarchist (he disassociated himself from the antics of the Push), but he came close to the classical liberal position in his preference for a minimal, non-interventionist state. Molnar, on the other hand, was an anarchist, and found aspects of his mentor's realist philosophy and its attendant "politics of criticism" useful for rethinking post-war anarchism. "The view of [anarchism] as something that will change the whole of society in favour of freedom has always depended on certain errors", he argued, "those who criticise Proudhon, Bakunin, Kropotkin, and the rest of being utopian are usually not blind to these errors. As a matter of fact, such criticism consists mainly of an exposure of the false optimism of nineteenth century anarchist theory".⁴⁰

Molnar thought the classical anarchists made three incorrect assumptions. First, that a social revolution would spontaneously come from below once the people had been properly illuminated about their oppression. Second, that people were naturally co-operative or innately reasonable. Third, that history was progressive and therefore on their side. The first two assumptions ignored the fact that "unanimous agreement is clearly impossible if people are in conflict on various demands and, equally, the most powerful propaganda is doomed to failure where it goes against vested interests".⁴¹ In their more sober moments, the nineteenth-century anarchists had understood this. Bakunin accepted peaceful persuasion could never touch the heart of the rich. He was also aware of the problem with over-determining human nature. "The people" were no unified group, "[Bakunin] found that artisans such as for instance, blacksmiths, show signs of revolutionary instincts while others, mainly better paid craftsmen, have distinctly bourgeois ambitions and outlook".

As for the claim about history's inevitable advance toward greater and higher forms of living, the events of recent years – the War and the continuing wave of violence that followed – showed this was clearly absurd. Again, anarchists from Bakunin to Kropotkin had known this, indeed their refusal to dictate a blueprint for the future set them apart from the Marxists. In his more sober writings, Kropotkin openly recognised that the struggle between authority and liberty was perpetual.

The alternative to making extravagant claims about revolution, nature or history lay in taking seriously this notion of two endlessly struggling traditions. Molnar believed anarchists should confine themselves to maintaining the struggle, but doing this involved a rethinking of political practice. “[T]he ‘*permanent protest*’ implied by this is carried on without the promise of final triumph but in a spirit of ‘*distrusting your masters and distrusting your emancipators*’ and with no intention of wanting to make the world safe for freedom”. Non-utopian anarchism might seem futile but only because it refused “to deal in terms of success or failure, in not attempting to carry out, or even propose, wise, all-embracing policies that bear on the whole of society and are meant to further *the* final revolution”.⁴²

As Stafford pointed out, Molnar's case for “permanent protest” had clear traction with Berlin's critique of positive liberty, and even advanced it by turning criticism into a political project in its own right. Unsurprisingly, given his own empathy with the “Open Society”, Ward welcomed the rejection of “perfectionism, utopian fantasy, conspiratorial romanticism, revolutionary optimism”, but, even with his reservations about utopia as a political stimulant, he could not entirely follow the Australian's austerity. Just because no roads led to utopia, it did not mean that “no roads lead anywhere. All roads lead somewhere and if you undertake the responsibility of choosing, what guides you in your choice?”⁴³

One way to keep utopia grounded was by locating in common places and keeping action towards it small and limited. Anarchists should illuminate

the extent to which we choose, or accept, or are fobbed off with, or lack the imagination and inventiveness to discover alternatives to, the authoritarian solutions to small problems because this would prepare people for challenging ‘the extent to which we are their powerless victims in big affairs’.⁴⁴

The simplest way of doing this was to spotlight examples of anarchist principles already in action in everyday life and show how these might be enhanced.

Constructive propaganda

French historian Gaston Leval took up this idea of everyday utopianism, drawing on his many years as an activist and the main chronicler of the Spanish anarchist collectives to do so. In “A Constructive Libertarian Movement”, he regretted anarchism's tendency to define itself negatively, spotlighting what it rejected rather than what it wanted. While accepting that philosophically this might be sound, it was strategically short-sighted. By constantly criticising but never suggesting alternatives, anarchists disturbed the social imagination but did not expand it.

Leval believed Kropotkin understood this better than most. *Mutual Aid* (1902) took on Charles Darwin's *Origin of the Species*, the most influential scientific and, consequently, social theory of its day, and countered with an equally compelling case that co-operation, not just competition, was also integral to humanity's evolution. Accepting even the

possibility that anarchism had a biological basis was enough to justify promoting a “constructive psychology”, a mindset where people believed they could take effective action to change their societies. Leval concluded by calling on anarchists, especially those who were orators or writers, to examine practical examples of how people organised without authority (as he had with the Spanish collectives) and describe to people how they worked.⁴⁵

Was this an adequate compromise? Leval’s “constructive psychology” was pedagogical rather than didactic in that it showed alternatives rather than defined direction. In this, it was distinct from Read and Comfort. Even so, P.D.K. Hill still worried that it reduced anarchy to “a set of rules, formulae, doctrines, to be enunciated by libertarian sociologists and economists” and passed down for the people to implement.⁴⁶ Coming to Leval’s defence, Ward argued that the Frenchman had *not* said Kropotkin *proved* anarchism was scientific in origin, only that he used legitimate scientific methods to make his case for the importance of co-operation to human evolution. Nor was Leval arguing for an anarchist sociology, only that anarchists continue to engage with contemporary ideas and base their arguments on current social facts. If anarchism was ever to intrude on the cultural mainstream as a serious force (which, as an aspiring popular movement, it must surely wish to do), it should meet people on their own terms.⁴⁷

Ward’s appreciation of Leval’s “constructive psychology” aligned with his broader theory of propaganda and its intellectual relevance to anarchism. Throughout his life, he resolutely rejected the label anarchist thinker, insisting, instead, he was a propagandist.⁴⁸ This was not false modesty on his part but fundamental to his political thinking. Anarchism, as he understood it, must be voluntary and spontaneous to be consistent with its insistence on individual liberty. The goal of the anarchist propagandist was not to perfect ideas about anarchism, only to spread them, and to do so in such a way as to inspire people to act on them. The most effective way to do this was by putting them into the common languages (broadly defined) of the day and connecting them to contemporary problems. Doing this not only made them accessible to people but it also revitalised the movement by constantly infusing it with new subject matter to work on.

His thinking on this subject was shaped by his decade of experience writing for *Freedom*. Under the chief editorship of Vernon Richards, the prevailing influence on the paper was Richard’s family friend Errico Malatesta (1853–1932). Malatesta, too, was cautious about claiming too much for anarchism as a scientific theory. Regardless of whether it was one, the practical Italian felt this was too remote for most people and that was more important. Anarchism had to feel urgent and meaningful to people’s lives as they experienced them. The job for the writer, then, was “provoking by propaganda and action, all kinds of individual and collective initiatives” and “pushing people to demand to seize all the freedom they can and to make themselves responsible for providing their own needs”.⁴⁹

More peculiar to Ward was the influence of Alexander Herzen (1812–1870), the Russian anarchist, journalist and editor of *The Bell*, who provided him with an ethical model. Herzen was a familiar name among anarchists, but here, again, Ward’s reading of him was mediated by Berlin and his “A Marvellous Decade” lecture series on Russian thinkers, as well as accompanying articles in *Encounter* and a translation of Herzen’s *The Other Shore*.⁵⁰ As Caryl Emerson pointed out, Berlin’s Herzen was highly selective, (over)emphasising the liberalism of his middle years over the radicalism youth or (unusually) the utopianism of his old age.⁵¹ This

was true, but it is likely the agonies of doubt Herzen suffered during that period of his life, poignantly confessed through an imagined dialogue in *The Other Shore*, resonated with the same kind of problems Berlin was wrestling with in the mid-1950s as he reflected on the dilemmas of Liberalism.

Herzen's crisis of faith in the mid-nineteenth century spoke to Cold War anarchism as much as it did to Cold War liberalism because it referred to a mutual problem: you cannot force people to be free, but you cannot free people without force, so what should you do? Among the *Freedom* group, others were well aware of the link but considered Herzen more of a warning than an example. Woodcock, for example, remarked (*italics my own*):

the study of an ironic figure like Alexander Herzen will show that, even in the great era of revolutionary upsurge, the *disorders* of doubt and disillusionment were already present. It is because he suffered so much from these modern maladies, because he was so much the revolutionary *malgre lui*, that Herzen possesses an almost contemporary interest.⁵²

By contrast, Ward felt Herzen's doubt made him more attractive. The pulse of uncertainty running through all his writing made his politics more appealing, too. In this, Ward sympathised with Berlin's interest in the middle years and even took an additional step. He noticed how Herzen carefully avoided repeating his contemporaries' claims about the inevitability of socialism, nor would he urge people to join any revolutionary cause or movement. The Russian, Ward concluded approvingly, "believed that simply to spread enlightenment was more revolutionary in the long run".⁵³

Given this background, "constructive psychology" satisfied Ward's ethical and practical criteria for propaganda, but Rita Milton, the British movement's best orator, had doubts. Raised in Glasgow, in a socialist family where great stress had been placed on mobilising the workers for the coming collapse of capitalism, Milton was thrilled to encounter anarchism with its devotion to personal freedom. Moving to London in 1947, she fell in with the *Freedom* group and became a regular at Hyde Park speakers' corner, as well as a favourite on London's debating club scene. In 1952, she was the first *Freedom* anarchist to appear on British television, where she debated representatives from the National Council for Marriage Guidance.⁵⁴

While sharing *Freedom's* general commitment to anarchism as a revolutionary popular movement, Milton was an individualist, later describing how "the notion of I, I, I is not a very appealing notion, but it's one I quite enjoy and it lets me say this is what I think and this is what I'm going to do". As such, she viewed any intrusion into personal sovereignty with suspicion. "The issues raised by CW ... are of great interest to this negative propagandist", she teased, as they made her reflect on her "destructive critical methods", but she was unconvinced by the approach and the philosophy it was based on. "The question is should we abandon our 'little criticisms' and embark on a programme of activity suggested by Leval and in so doing convince people of our seriousness and the value of a free society?"

From her experience, she thought "that at best the response to our free society 'blue print' is one of gentle derision. But most people find it hard to argue with us when we are criticising this society",

people can relate our criticism of government, etc, to their everyday experience, they know what we are saying is true. As yet they cannot think beyond the governmental society or

conceive of a new one without the shortcomings of the old. Perhaps they never will but I am convinced that attempting to build without first destroying is a futile kind of activity. In recent years I have been impressed by the group described as the ‘angry young men’, particularly among writers. They have been accused of negativism but I share the view that merely standing against a stream moving towards destruction is a positive kind of negativism and is among the few things we can do today to express our disgust and anger. We should not be afraid of the title, ‘simple agitators’.⁵⁵

Milton believed authoritarianism was so deeply rooted in mainstream mentality that, until it was thoroughly destroyed, no one would even comprehend the spirit of suggestion in Leval’s “constructive propaganda”. In fact, they would seize on and condemn its lack of cohesion just as readily as they mocked fully fledged anarchist utopias. Like Molnar, Milton saw the politics of criticism as “a positive kind of negativism” in so far as breaking the thrall and dependence on authoritarianism was a precondition for any more serious revolutionary activity.

Ward still found this too narrow. Every anarchist who spoke publicly encountered the same set of questions: who would do the dirty jobs in an anarchist society? What about delinquency and crime in a society without authority? How would you protect the vulnerable without the state? In other words, how would an anarchist society actually *work*? If anarchism was ever to be taken seriously, it had to address these sensibly. In doing so, there need be no hard border between criticism and construction, after all, there was more than one way to criticise. You should be oppositional, as Molnar and Milton argued, exposing the false claims of power, but you could also be pluralist and weaken power by showing a rich abundance of valid alternatives. As such, you might criticise division of labour on the one hand while promoting myriad forms of workers’ control on the other, or you could relate crime to social marginalisation while pointing to the histories of co-operative societies in organising independent social protection.⁵⁶

There was also a new generation to think about, those students and young people politicised by Suez and Aldermaston but uncertain what to do next. Many of them hovered around the fringes of the New Left Clubs but were instinctively suspicious of socialism. As one contemporary put it, they were not romantic or especially ambitious, they cared more about what was bogus or phoney than what was cruel or wicked, “their commitment is essentially autonomous antinomian, adhering to no ideology and demanding no shibboleths – it is commitment in the age of the Cold War, the Welfare State, and the Affluent Society”.⁵⁷ They did not want utopia but, at the same time, they were not content with criticism alone, as one club leader reported, they wanted to be *doing* things.⁵⁸

A readers’ survey conducted by the paper in 1960 reflected these reservations. Comments included:

Please be broader and more scientific also drop that halo of knowing positively everything.

Less carping and more anarchist explanation in a readable manner so that people who are not too bright will begin to see what it’s about.

We should get down to anarchist applications in our world as it is. I believe the only way to anything is to begin in however small a way in the situation in which one finds oneself.⁵⁹

To meet these demands and put his own theory of critical-constructive propaganda to the test, Ward launched *Anarchy* (A), which he described as

a journal of anarchist applications and techniques: the techniques of ‘encroaching control’ in industry, of ‘de-institutionalization’ in the organisation of social welfare, of applying in the ordinary primary and secondary schools the lessons of the progressive schools, of encouraging and widening the field of the habit of direct action.⁶⁰

During his decade-long editorship, he combined classic, staple anarchist topics like workers’ control, syndicalism (A2) and the Spanish Civil War (A5) with topical issues like selective education (A21), crime and delinquency (A9, A15), sex (A20), housing (A23), militant pacifism (A13, A14), African independence (A16) and the “new wave” in film and literature (A1).

More important than the journal’s content, however, was its house style. *Anarchy* eschewed all the conventional hallmarks of radical writing. The tone was restrained and studiously reasonable. The carefully curated case studies of mutual aid were reflective, not exhortatory. In A7 on children’s “junkyard” adventure playgrounds (which encouraged discovery learning), play leaders Sheila Meskine and Annie Mygind confessed their struggle to work in communities where residents were hostile to the playgrounds.⁶¹ In A92, celebrated progressive headteacher Michael Duane of Risinghill School (Islington, London, 1960–1965) was criticised for not engaging staff and parents with his ideas or involving them in his efforts to liberalise the school.⁶² In A83 on housing, Ward analysed why housing co-operatives in Britain usually failed despite theoretically being the fairest method of housing people.⁶³ Some articles were even subject to an informal peer review. In A4 on de-institutionalisation, Ward sent his case for dismantling state-controlled welfare to John Vaizey, an economist at the London School of Economics. Vaizey’s reply regretting Ward’s failure to identify plausible alternative sources of social support appeared in the following issue.⁶⁴

Despite, or rather because of these conscientious efforts, *Anarchy* faced similar criticisms to those levelled at Berlin’s “Two Concepts”. Indeed, Bookchin, when invited to comment in the journal, drew a direct link, describing *Anarchy*’s brand of anarchy as Cold War liberalism repackaged, and no less guilty of handwringing meliorism and political impotence.⁶⁵ Woodcock granted the journal was “more flexible and mature”, but agreed it reduced anarchism to “a trend of the young and especially the middle-class young”, in essence, “a revolution—not of the under-privileged—but of the privileged who have seen the futility of affluence as a goal; it is strongly reminiscent of the movement of guilty noblemen in Russia during the 19th century”. Given its bourgeois character, it was unlikely the outcome would be an egalitarian non-governmental society, rather it would lead to “the development of forms of democracy more sensitive to modern conditions”.⁶⁶

In “The Anarchist Idea”, Ward flipped their critique on its head. “It is a pity” he wrote, “that both the recent histories of anarchism insist on treating it simply as one of the more interesting offshoots of socialism which finally died when Franco’s troops entered Barcelona in 1939”. Persisting in this “millenarian” view missed the whole nuance of anarchism’s criticism of politics. The anarchist could no more ignore the obvious contradiction in forcing people to be free than the negative, “Open Society” liberal could. They had, then, to be “an advocate of a different kind of social order from the one that surrounds us” and, grasping that “the political processes which are the accepted vehicles of social change are not those in which he sees it useful to participate”, operate outside and around them. Being on the outside did not have to mean paralysis, there was

a way forward. “We live in the society we’ve got, but we want to change it. We want to spread the anarchist idea, we want to popularise the anarchist method”.⁶⁷

Conclusion

As Moyn argued, Cold War liberals undermined the idea that a commitment to liberty was compatible with a strong programme for the defence or advancement of liberalism. Intellectuals like Berlin accepted that liberty without equality or justice was impoverished but still insisted that implementing a scheme of redistributive or protective measures could not be done in the name of liberty. Yet the alternative seemed no less self-defeating; the fragmentation and diffusion entailed by privileging personal liberty over all else inevitably frustrated the same measures necessary to extend and improve the quality of liberty for all.

These problems and their implications for political commitment were magnified among post-war British anarchists as they rethought anarchism as a revolutionary social movement for a free society in a sceptical, nuclear age. Read and Comfort answered the challenge by retheorising revolutionary methods. In place of anarchism as a head-on collision with power followed by the implementation of a fully integrated “Anarchist society”, they proposed a gradual, piecemeal, but still systematic approach to change, pegged to a sophisticated scientific understanding of human nature and social development.

Molnar and Milton agreed on the need to break from inherited concepts of revolution but extended that further to include any lingering promise of an ideal social order aligned with a true natural order, no matter how elusive or purely motivational that ultimately proved to be. The only way anarchism could be plausible and consistent was as a whole way of struggle. To this, Leval and Ward added a constructive, capacity-building element which Ward, through *Anarchy*, transformed into a “radical realism” aesthetic aimed at popularising anarchist ideas – rather than anarchism *per se* – and making them accessible to non-anarchists.

From these arguments, the shape of a loose two-part strategy emerged at the dawn of the sixties. As a formal, organised movement, anarchism should restrict itself to opposing power whenever and wherever it accrued (this included progressive forces no less than the traditional establishment). At the same time, it should also pursue a more ambitious but strictly informal or “soft” component of anarchy education, seizing all possible opportunities to promote, but not prescribe, people’s capacity to organise independently.

Viewing the dilemmas of Cold War liberalism through the *Freedom* debates does not dissolve them, but shows the extent to which a pluralist, non-determinist and dynamic account of liberty challenged conventional political thinking. As such, it cannot be dismissed as a straightforwardly conservative position. While it limited any prospective political programme in a normative sense, it did not preclude other kinds of socially transformative activity. Preserving space for free action did not necessarily end politics because, as Berlin himself conceded in “Two Concepts”, people were so interdependent that the frontier between private choice and public impact must always be a matter of argument.⁶⁸ Anarchism, with its rich tradition of recognising alternative foci of action, adapted more readily, in some quarters, to this kind of “positive negativism” and its attendant tasks of disrupting and dispersing power.

Notes

1. Berlin, "Two Concepts of Liberty", 166–217.
2. MacCullum, "Negative and Positive Freedom", 312–34.
3. Taylor, "What's Wrong with Negative Liberty", 175–93.
4. Hirschman, "Toward a Feminist Theory of Freedom", 46–7.
5. Skinner, *Liberty Before Liberalism*; Pettit, *Republicanism*.
6. Crowder, *Isaiah Berlin*.
7. Muller, "The Contours of Cold War Liberalism", 37–56.
8. Moyn, *Liberalism Against Itself*.
9. Cherniss, *Liberalism in Dark Times*.
10. Berlin, "Two Concepts of Liberty", 195.
11. Pauli, "The New Anarchism in Britain and the US", 134–55; Honeywell, *A British Anarchist Tradition*. See also, Graeber, "The New Anarchists", 70.
12. Davis, "Social Anarchism", 62–82.
13. Meltzer, *The Anarchists in London*; Woodcock, *Anarchism*; Bookchin, *Social Anarchism or Lifestyle Anarchism*.
14. Price, "The Two Main Trends", 1.
15. Adams, "Sleeping Dogs and Rebellious Hopes", 1093–106.
16. Adams, "The Anarchist and the Technocrat", 301–22.
17. Stafford, "The Anarchists in Britain Today", 82–104.
18. Read, "Anarchism: Past and Future", 2.
19. Kropotkin, *Ethics: Origins and Development*, 13, 18, 22.
20. Adams, *Kropotkin, Read*, 50–61.
21. Goodway, *Anarchist Seeds*, 175–203.
22. Adams, *Kropotkin, Read*, 50–61.
23. Read, *Education Through Art*, 1, 232.
24. Read, "Anarchism Past and Future", 2.
25. Comfort, "Philosophies in Little", 38.
26. Comfort, "Delinquency and Authority", 2; Comfort, "Delinquency and Authority II", 2.
27. Craig, "Letter", 4; McDonald, "Letter", 4; Meltzer, "Letter", 4.
28. Parker, "The Psychiatric Approach", 4.
29. Honeywell, *A British Anarchist Tradition*, 133–82; Goodway, *Seeds Beneath the Snow*, 309–25; Shantz and Williams, *Anarchy and Society*, 40–50.
30. Scott-Brown, *Colin Ward*, 1–17; White, "Making Anarchism Respectable?", 11–28.
31. Ward, "Letter", 4.
32. Ward, "Anarchism and the Open Society", 2.
33. Ward, "Anarchism and the Open Society II", 2.
34. Huggon, "Letter: The Open Society", 4.
35. Read, *Anarchy and Order*, 19.
36. Ward, "Anarchy for Adults", 2.
37. Black, *Redefining British Politics*, 1–7.
38. Baker, *Australian Realism*.
39. Anderson, "The Servile State", 115–32.
40. Molnar, "Anarchy and Utopia", 2.
41. Molnar, "Anarchy and Utopia-2", 2.
42. Ibid.
43. Ward, "Anarchy for Adults", 2.
44. Ward, "The Unwritten Handbook", 2.
45. Leval, "A Constructive Libertarian Movement", 2, 4.
46. Hill, "Letter", 4.
47. Ward, "Constructive Anarchism", 2.
48. Goodway and Ward, *Talking Anarchy*, 105.
49. Malatesta and Richards, *The Life and Times of Errico Malatesta*, 170.

50. Berlin, "Alexander Herzen and his Memoirs", 499–524; Herzen and Berlin, *From the Other Shore*, 128.
51. Emerson, "Isaiah Berlin and Mikhail Bakhtin", 139–64.
52. Woodcock, *The Writer and Politics*, 56–7.
53. Ward, *Influences*, 49–64.
54. Gibson, "Interview with Rita Milton".
55. Milton, "A Comment on Constructive Anarchism", 2.
56. Ward, "Discussion on Constructive Anarchism", 2.
57. Walter, "The New Wave", 27–32.
58. ULR, "ULR Committee Meeting Minutes, 7 July 1959".
59. Editors, "Freedom Readership Survey", 4.
60. Ward, "The Future of Anarchism–3", 176.
61. Mygind, "New Town Adventure", 202–3; Meskine, "Adventure in Lollard Street", 204–13.
62. Small, "About Risinghill", 289–305.
63. Ward, "Tenants Take Over", 1–19.
64. Ward, "Where the Shoe Pinches", 97–116; Vaizey, "Observations on *Anarchy* 4", 219.
65. Bookchin, "Against Meliorism", 191–2.
66. Woodcock, *Anarchism*, 458.
67. Ward, "The Anarchist Idea", 197.
68. Berlin, "Two Concepts", 171.

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